

YOU UNIVERSITY

The Mental Game Workbook

A seven-unit training camp for the six inches between your ears, built to go with *WINNING STATE Wrestling* by Steve Knight.

WRESTLER _____

WEIGHT / YEAR _____

PERSISTENT · CONSISTENT · RESILIENT · RELENTLESS

KEEP WRESTLING - EVERYDAY IS A NEW MATCH!

An independent Merrill companion. Not written by, endorsed by, or affiliated with Steve Knight or Let's Win! International. Use it alongside your own copy of the book.

START HERE

How YOU University works

This is not homework. It's a training plan for the part of wrestling nobody can see from the bleachers.

1 LEARN
Read the book section and the Learn page. 5 minutes.

2 BUILD
Make your own tool: your words, your cues.

3 MAT TEST
Use it in a real drill. Pick A or B.

4 REWIND
Days later, recall it without peeking. That's how it sticks.

THE DEAL

You choose. Your cues, your Mat Test, your words. Generic answers don't help you, and nobody is grading this.

You prove it. Progress means evidence: a tally, a date, a moment on the mat. Not a feeling.

You're not alone. Several Mat Tests use a partner. Helping a teammate get 1% better is part of the work.

Your privacy. You decide what you share. You can always answer privately or out loud instead of in writing.

WHAT THE LABELS MEAN

FROM THE BOOK — Knight's idea, paraphrased from his publisher's own descriptions. Source keys like [K6] are listed on the last page. Always check it against your copy.

THE SCIENCE — Peer-reviewed research. Source keys like [S7].

MERRILL — Merrill program language: the Core Four, Coach Arnie's routines and prompts.

YOU UNIVERSITY ORIGINAL — Exercises written for this workbook. They are NOT from the book.

THE SEASON MAP: EACH UNIT BUILDS ON THE LAST

1. **Warrior First** — Close the gap between Practice-you and Match-you
2. **Love Nerves** — Read your body's signals as fuel and find YOUR ready zone
3. **Breathe Like a Bluejay** — Use Long Breath and Quick Reset on command
4. **BIG DOG Talk** — Turn little-dog thoughts into BIG DOG cues
5. **Bank the Proof** — Build a Confidence Bank and a BIG-DOG highlight reel
6. **Go-Time** — Run Go-Time scripts and If-Then plans
7. **Flip the Switch** — Build a Competition Process, a First Job, and a reset loop
★ **Be You** — Put it all on one card and wrestle like you

BASELINE

Starting Line

A snapshot, not a test or a diagnosis. Honest beats impressive.

★ MERRILL

Merrill's **Five Cs** (from Coach Arnie's packet). Circle 1-10 for how often this shows up in REAL MATCHES, then write one piece of evidence. The total isn't the point. The pattern is.

C	1 = RARELY	10 = EVERY MATCH	EVIDENCE (A REAL MOMENT)
Commitment *Dedication to the work and the goal*	1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10		
Courage *Willingness to attempt, engage, and face challenge*	1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10		
Concentration *Keep or return attention to the job*	1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10		
Control *Regulate your response and stay useful*	1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10		
Confidence *Belief supported by preparation, mastery, and evidence*	1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10		

The moment in a match where my mind most often gets in my way:

If this workbook works, what will a teammate SEE me doing differently by February?

TRACK IT

Progress + Book Log

Check a box when it's true, not when the page is done.

UNIT	READ THE BOOK SECTION	BUILT THE TOOL	MAT TEST DONE	USED IN A MATCH	REWIND PASSED
1. Warrior First					
2. Love Nerves					
3. Breathe Like a Bluejay					
4. BIG DOG Talk					
5. Bank the Proof					
6. Go-Time					
7. Flip the Switch					

MY BOOK LOG: *WINNING STATE WRESTLING* HAS 7 CHAPTERS. TRACK THEM IN YOUR OWN WORDS.

CH.	TITLE (FROM YOUR COPY)	THE BIG IDEA, IN MY WORDS	UNIT IT CONNECTS TO
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			

UNIT 1 / LEARN

1% Better

Warrior First

Mental toughness is trained, not born.

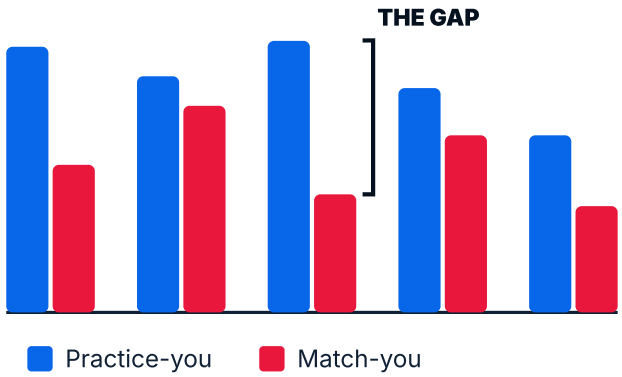
Skill you'll own: Close the gap between Practice-you and Match-you

MATCH MOMENT

Tuesday in the room you hit your single-leg finish on everybody. Saturday at the quad, first match, you never take a shot. Same legs. Same technique. What changed?

Before you read on: what would YOU do in the next 5 seconds?

Same skills, two settings. The gap is trainable.



FROM THE BOOK

Knight's publisher frames Winning State around one promise: wrestle in competition as well as, or better than, you wrestle in practice. He argues mental toughness is built with tactics, not genetics, and that it is not the same thing as confidence. Confidence is a feeling that comes and goes. Toughness is what you do when doubt shows up anyway. [K1 K2 K5 K6]

Find it in your copy: Chapter ____ Page ____

One line from the book that stuck with me (write it, then say it in your own words):

THE SCIENCE

Mental skills work like technique: they improve when practiced, not when admired. Imagery, self-talk, and pre-match routines have all improved performance in controlled studies, including studies of athletes your age. Doubt before a match is normal. It isn't proof that you're soft. [S1 S12 S14]

MERRILL

1% Better is the engine of YOU University: one usable skill at a time, and one controllable focus a day (Today's 1%). This unit finds the gap you'll aim your 1% at.

UNIT 1 / BUILD YOUR TOOL

1% Better

The Gap Map

YOU UNIVERSITY ORIGINAL

Rate each skill twice: how it shows up in the practice room, and how it shows up in real matches. 1 = rarely, 5 = every time.

SKILL (COACH ARNIE'S EXAMPLES + YOURS)	PRACTICE-ME	MATCH-ME	GAP
Good stance the whole time	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	
Hand-fighting to set up shots	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	
Single-leg finish	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	
Fast stand-up on bottom	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	
Stay calm after a mistake	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	
My own: _____	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	

What shows up in matches that isn't there in practice? (crowd, scoreboard, her record, who's watching...)

My biggest gap, written as ONE behavior I can control (Today's 1%):

UNIT 1 / TEST IT ON THE MAT

1% Better

MAT TEST

Your choice: pick ONE. A skill you only write about is a skill you don't have.

☐ **A. Pressure Rep**

Ask your coach to add stakes to one live go: start down 0-2, 30 seconds, team watching. Did your 1% behavior show up? Tally it.

Date tried: _____ Tally / result:

☐ **B. Practice Like It's Saturday**

Before your first live go, do your real match warm-up and walk to center like it's a match. Compare how you wrestle to a normal go.

Date tried: _____ Tally / result:

HONEST REFLECTION

Specifics beat feelings. Name the period, the position, the words.

1 Think of your last real match. Name one moment (period, score, position) when Match-you wrestled differently than Practice-you. What were you thinking right before it?

2 Knight separates feeling confident from being tough. Describe a time you did NOT feel confident but did the tough thing anyway. What exactly did you do?

REWIND: NO PEEKING / PREDICT

PREDICT (no wrong answers): What's one thing you think the best wrestlers do with their minds that you don't do yet?

Then check back. Got it? ☐ yes ☐ partly ☐ not yet

SKILL LADDER

- ☐ **I can explain it** to a teammate without notes
- ☐ **I used it in practice** date _____
- ☐ **I used it in a match** date _____
- ☐ **It went into my "What Works for Me"** (p. 27)

UNIT 2 / LEARN

Be You

Love Nerves

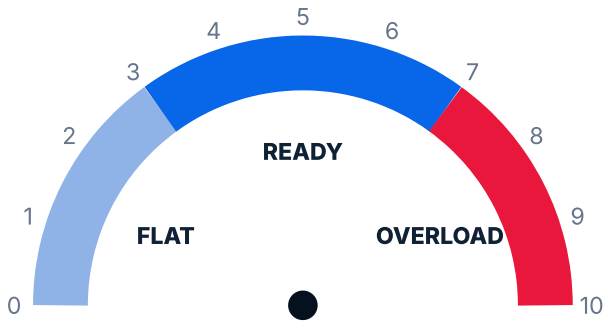
Your body isn't scared. It's getting ready.

Skill you'll own: Read your body's signals as fuel and find YOUR ready zone

MATCH MOMENT

Bullpen at regionals. Your stomach flips, your hands are cold and sweaty, and your legs feel shaky. The girl next to you looks totally calm. Your brain says: something's wrong with me.

Before you read on: what would YOU do in the next 5 seconds?



Your READY band may differ from a teammate's.

FROM THE BOOK

In the publisher's 7-part article series, Knight's Tactic #1 is Love Nerves. Nerves don't go away, even for elite athletes, so the job is to use them. His article on adrenaline treats it as a power source to contain and use, not a sign that something is wrong. [K3 K4 K6]

Find it in your copy: Chapter ____ Page ____

One line from the book that stuck with me (write it, then say it in your own words):

THE SCIENCE

Anxiety and excitement feel almost the same in your body: fast heart, quick breath, buzzing energy. In experiments, people who said "I am excited" performed better than people who told themselves "I am calm" (Brooks, 2014). Each athlete also has a personal ready zone. Some wrestle best fired up and others steadier (Hanin's IZOF model). [S4 S5 S6]

MERRILL

Be You: your best number on the dial belongs to you. You don't have to look calm like the girl next to you in the bullpen. You have to find your own ready zone.

UNIT 2 / BUILD YOUR TOOL

Be You

Signal → Story → Fuel

YOU UNIVERSITY ORIGINAL

Catch the signal, notice the little-dog story you attach to it, then translate it into fuel. One row is done for you.

BODY SIGNAL	LITTLE-DOG STORY	FUEL TRANSLATION
Heart pounding	"I'm freaking out."	"My body is sending blood to my muscles."

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

FLAT — Circle your usual bullpen number. Star your best-match number. — OVERLOAD

What pushes me OVER my zone? What drops me UNDER it?

My UP-SHIFT move (when I'm flat) and my DOWN-SHIFT move (when I'm overloaded):

UNIT 2 / TEST IT ON THE MAT

Be You

MAT TEST

Your choice: pick ONE. A skill you only write about is a skill you don't have.

☐ **A. Read-Rate-Wrestle**

Before 3 live goes: rate your number, say your fuel line (quietly is fine), wrestle, then rate how well you wrestled. Look for your pattern.

Date tried: _____ Tally / result:

☐ **B. Center-Mat Rep**

Coach puts two wrestlers in the center for a 30-second go while the team watches. Use "I'm excited" or your own fuel line before the whistle.

Date tried: _____ Tally / result:

HONEST REFLECTION

Specifics beat feelings. Name the period, the position, the words.

1 Your best match ever: what number were you on the dial? How do you know? Describe what your body and mind were doing.

2 Give one real example of nerves that HELPED you and one that FROZE you. What was different between the two moments?

REWIND: NO PEEKING

UNIT 1: In one sentence, what's the gap between Practice-you and Match-you?

UNIT 1: What does Knight say confidence is NOT?

Then check back. Got it? ☐ yes ☐ partly ☐ not yet

SKILL LADDER

- ☐ **I can explain it** to a teammate without notes
- ☐ **I used it in practice** date _____
- ☐ **I used it in a match** date _____
- ☐ **It went into my "What Works for Me"** (p. 27)

UNIT 3 / LEARN

Core Four Breath

Breathe Like a Bluejay

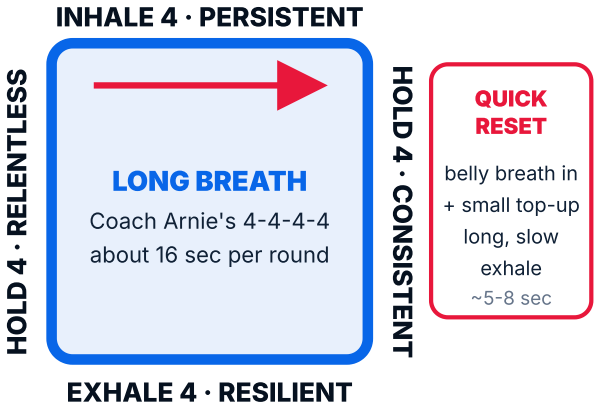
The one part of your stress response you can steer on purpose.

Skill you'll own: Use Long Breath and Quick Reset on command

MATCH MOMENT

Out of bounds, down 3-1, 40 seconds left in the second. The ref is bringing you back to center. You have about 8 seconds, your chest is heaving, and your mind is on the scoreboard.

Before you read on: what would YOU do in the next 5 seconds?



FROM THE BOOK

Knight teaches Gut Breathing as a skill to calm nerves and sharpen focus. His adrenaline article names systematic breathing as the way to bring the surge "down a notch" without losing your fire. [K4 K6]

Find it in your copy: Chapter ____ Page ____

One line from the book that stuck with me (write it, then say it in your own words):

THE SCIENCE

In a randomized study, five minutes a day of slow breathing with a long exhale lowered breathing rate and improved mood and anxiety more than a mindfulness control (Balban et al., 2023). The exhale is your brake pedal. If you ever feel dizzy, stop and breathe normally. [S7]

MERRILL

Coach Arnie's 4-4-4-4 routine puts the Core Four into every breath: Inhale 4 = Persistent. Hold 4 = Consistent. Exhale 4 = Resilient. Hold 4 = Relentless.

UNIT 3 / BUILD YOUR TOOL

Core Four Breath

Breath Lab

YOU UNIVERSITY ORIGINAL

Test it like a scientist. Count your breaths for 30 seconds (or check your pulse), do the tool, then count again.

TRIAL	BREATHS / 30S BEFORE	AFTER	FEELING 0-10 BEFORE	AFTER
At rest, Long Breath x3				
After a hard drill, Long Breath x3				
After a hard drill, Quick Reset x2				

Read the data honestly. If nothing changed, that's useful too. Try the other tool or a slower exhale, and test again.

Where in a match do I get about 8 seconds? (out-of-bounds, between periods, injury time, choice...) List 3:

I'll use LONG BREATH when... I'll use QUICK RESET when...

UNIT 3 / TEST IT ON THE MAT

Core Four Breath

MAT TEST

Your choice: pick ONE. A skill you only write about is a skill you don't have.

☐ **A. Whistle Reset**

After every live-go whistle today, do one Quick Reset before you're back in your stance. Your partner tallies how many you remember.

Date tried: _____ Tally / result:

☐ **B. Core Four Warm-Up**

Run three rounds of 4-4-4-4 (say the Pillar words in your head) right before your first live go. Rate your focus 1-10 afterward.

Date tried: _____ Tally / result:

HONEST REFLECTION

Specifics beat feelings. Name the period, the position, the words.

1 When did your breathing get away from you today? Name the position and the drill. What happened to your wrestling in the next 10 seconds?

2 Which felt more useful, Long Breath or Quick Reset? Name the exact moment this week you'll use it.

REWIND: NO PEEKING

UNIT 2: Translate this signal into fuel: "My legs feel shaky."

UNIT 1: Name the behavior you chose for Today's 1%.

Then check back. Got it? ☐ yes ☐ partly ☐ not yet

SKILL LADDER

- ☐ **I can explain it** to a teammate without notes
- ☐ **I used it in practice** date _____
- ☐ **I used it in a match** date _____
- ☐ **It went into my "What Works for Me"** (p. 27)

UNIT 4 / LEARN

Persistent

BIG DOG Talk

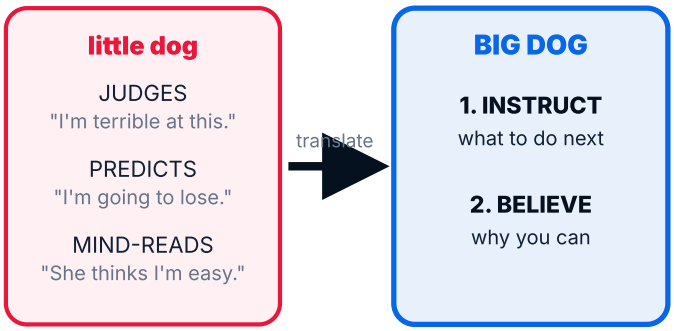
Talk to yourself like a great corner coach.

Skill you'll own: Turn little-dog thoughts into BIG DOG cues

MATCH MOMENT

You shoot a single, she sprawls hard and catches a front headlock. You fight out, but now you're thinking, "Don't shoot again, she'll just snap you down." It's the second period and you haven't attacked since.

Before you read on: what would YOU do in the next 5 seconds?



Short. About the effect you want. Practiced until automatic.

FROM THE BOOK

The Winning State series describes a little dog and a BIG Dog inside every competitor, and says the athletes who learn to control them leave victorious. Knight teaches that BIG-DOG self-talk is more than "positive" self-talk. It's competition talk you use to settle down and strengthen belief. [K6 K7 K3]

Find it in your copy: Chapter ____ Page ____

One line from the book that stuck with me (write it, then say it in your own words):

THE SCIENCE

A meta-analysis of self-talk studies found that it improves performance. Instruction cues help most with precise skills and motivation cues help most with effort, and practiced cues beat ones you make up on the spot (Hatzigeorgiadis et al., 2011). Cues about the effect you want ("drive through her") beat cues about body parts (Chua et al., 2021). Talking to yourself as "you" can make pressure easier to handle (Kross et al., 2014). [S1 S2 S3]

MERRILL

Persistent means you keep working when the first attempt doesn't work. BIG DOG talk is how persistence sounds in your head after a missed shot: the next instruction, not a verdict.

UNIT 4 / BUILD YOUR TOOL

Persistent

Cue Translator

YOU UNIVERSITY ORIGINAL

Write the little dog's exact words, then the BIG DOG answer in two parts: INSTRUCT (what to do next) and BELIEVE (why you can).

SITUATION	LITTLE DOG SAYS	BIG DOG: INSTRUCT	BIG DOG: BELIEVE
Missed shot, front headlock	"She's too strong."	"Head up, hands, circle out."	"You've fought out of worse."
Neutral:			
Top:			
Bottom:			

My go-to cue (2-4 words, about the EFFECT I want, not my body parts):

Say it as "you" (Ex: "You're fine. Hands, angle, finish."):

UNIT 4 / TEST IT ON THE MAT

Persistent

MAT TEST

Your choice: pick ONE. A skill you only write about is a skill you don't have.

☐ **A. Cue Count**

In drilling, after every missed rep, say your INSTRUCT cue and redo the rep. Your partner counts cues. Goal: no rep ends on a verdict.

Date tried: _____ Tally / result:

☐ **B. Little Dog Drill**

In light live, your partner calls wrestling-only little-dog lines ("You're tired," "She's got you"). You answer with your BIG DOG cue and keep moving. No personal comments, ever.

Date tried: _____ Tally / result:

HONEST REFLECTION

Specifics beat feelings. Name the period, the position, the words.

1 Write the exact words your little dog used at your last tough moment. Don't clean them up. When does that voice show up most: neutral, top, bottom, or before the match?

2 Which cue did you actually use today? Did it change what your body did? What's the evidence?

REWIND: NO PEEKING

UNIT 3: Count the 4-4-4-4 and write the Pillar word for each phase.

UNIT 1: Why isn't confidence enough by itself, according to Knight?

Then check back. Got it? ☐ yes ☐ partly ☐ not yet

SKILL LADDER

- ☐ **I can explain it** to a teammate without notes
- ☐ **I used it in practice** date _____
- ☐ **I used it in a match** date _____
- ☐ **It went into my "What Works for Me"** (p. 27)

HALFTIME CHECK / after Unit 4

Halftime: what's working?

Coaches adjust at halftime, and so do you. Close the book and answer from memory first.

TOOL	EXPLAIN IT IN ONE LINE (NO PEEKING)	EXACTLY WHEN I USE IT	TIMES USED IN A MATCH
Love Nerves / fuel line			0 1 2 +
Long Breath or Quick Reset			0 1 2 +
BIG DOG INSTRUCT + BELIEVE cue			0 1 2 +
Today's 1% (from Unit 1)			0 1 2 +

The tool that's earning its keep, and the evidence:

The tool that isn't working YET. What will I change (cue words, timing, when I practice it)?

YOU UNIVERSITY ORIGINAL

Teach-back: Explain one tool to a younger teammate in under a minute. Teaching is one of the fastest ways to find the holes in what you know.

Who I taught + the tool:

The question she asked that I couldn't fully answer:

UNIT 5 / LEARN

Consistent

Bank the Proof

Belief built on evidence, not hype.

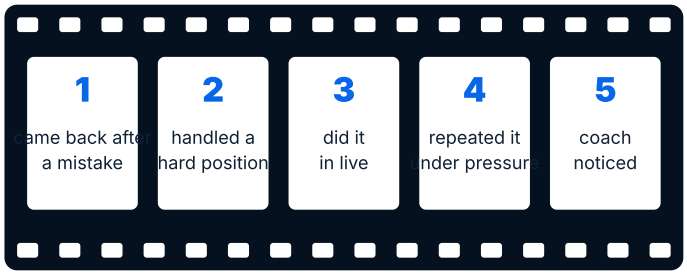
Skill you'll own: Build a Confidence Bank and a BIG-DOG highlight reel

MATCH MOMENT

The night before conference you see the bracket. Your first match is the girl who majored you in December, and your brain plays the December highlights on loop.

Before you read on: what would YOU do in the next 5 seconds?

YOUR BIG-DOG HIGHLIGHT REEL



Kinds of proof that count. Wins are optional. Responses are required.

FROM THE BOOK

Knight teaches athletes to build a BIG-DOG highlight reel of their own mentally tough successes: you've done it before, and you can do it again. He argues the goal is to believe you can succeed, not to chase a confidence feeling that can vanish in one exchange. [K6 K5]

Find it in your copy: Chapter ____ Page ____

One line from the book that stuck with me (write it, then say it in your own words):

THE SCIENCE

Your strongest source of self-belief is mastery: things you have actually done (Bandura, 1997). In a goal-setting meta-analysis, process goals produced large gains in self-efficacy (d = 1.11; Williamson et al., 2022). Real evidence beats empty affirmations because your brain can check it. [S8 S9]

MERRILL

The Merrill Confidence Bank stores proof, not empty affirmations. Consistent deposits every practice are what make it worth something on tournament day.

UNIT 5 / BUILD YOUR TOOL

Consistent

My BIG-DOG Highlight Reel

YOU UNIVERSITY ORIGINAL

Five clips of YOU being mentally tough. Rule: at least two must come from a loss, a bad day, or a hard practice. Toughness isn't the same as winning.

#	WHEN	SITUATION (PERIOD, POSITION, SCORE)	WHAT I DID	PILLAR
1				Per · Con Res · Rel
2				Per · Con Res · Rel
3				Per · Con Res · Rel
4				Per · Con Res · Rel
5				Per · Con Res · Rel

Circle the Pillar each clip shows. At least two clips come from a loss or a hard day.

WEEKLY DEPOSITS: one line of proof per practice

Mon _____

Tue _____

Wed _____

Thu _____

Fri _____

Sat _____

My 60-second pre-match replay, in order (clip #s and why that order):

_____

_____

_____

UNIT 5 / TEST IT ON THE MAT

Consistent

MAT TEST

Your choice: pick ONE. A skill you only write about is a skill you don't have.

☐ **A. Deposit Hunt**

Before you leave the room today, catch one moment for your bank and tell a teammate exactly what happened.

Date tried: _____ Tally / result:

☐ **B. Partner Scout**

Watch your partner's live goes. Give her one specific deposit ("You hit your stand-up after she broke you down twice") and she gives you one.

Date tried: _____ Tally / result:

HONEST REFLECTION

Specifics beat feelings. Name the period, the position, the words.

1 Pick your strongest clip. What would you have to believe about yourself to do that again on Saturday? What evidence supports that belief?

2 What kind of proof is missing from your bank (bottom? third period? a tough opponent?). What could you do this week to earn it?

REWIND: NO PEEKING

UNIT 4: Turn this into BIG DOG INSTRUCT + BELIEVE: "She's way stronger than me."

UNIT 2: What's your best-match number on the ready dial?

Then check back. Got it? ☐ yes ☐ partly ☐ not yet

SKILL LADDER

- ☐ **I can explain it** to a teammate without notes
- ☐ **I used it in practice** date _____
- ☐ **I used it in a match** date _____
- ☐ **It went into my "What Works for Me"** (p. 27)

UNIT 6 / LEARN

Relentless

Go-Time

Rehearse the fight, not the trophy.

Skill you'll own: Run Go-Time scripts and If-Then plans

MATCH MOMENT

You've pictured your high-crotch finish a hundred times. In the match she sprawls and whizzers, and the ref is warning you both for stalling. Nothing in your mental movie covered this.

Before you read on: what would YOU do in the next 5 seconds?

GO-TIME: REHEARSE THE FIGHT

SET	GO	GRIT	ANSWER
see · hear · feel	first attack	her answer	your adjustment

NOT THIS: Victory fantasy
hand raised, no obstacle, no plan

Frame 3 is where matches are decided.

FROM THE BOOK

Knight teaches Go-Time Visualization and calls it much stronger than visualizing "victory," because fantasizing about winning doesn't turn off doubt. [K6]

Find it in your copy: Chapter ____ Page ____

One line from the book that stuck with me (write it, then say it in your own words):

THE SCIENCE

Research agrees. Daydreaming only about success can drain the energy you bring (Oettingen & Mayer, 2002). Picturing the goal AND the obstacle, then making an if-then plan, helped high schoolers do 60% more practice work (Duckworth et al., 2011). Imagery improves motor skills in kids and teens (d = 0.49; Frank et al., 2023), especially when it's wrestling-specific and in real time. [S18 S10 S11 S12 S13]

MERRILL

Relentless means you keep creating pressure and action. In your head that means the movie keeps going after she sprawls, whizzers, or scores.

UNIT 6 / BUILD YOUR TOOL

Relentless

Go-Time Script + If-Then Plans

YOU UNIVERSITY ORIGINAL

Script one REAL exchange in four frames. Use what you'd SEE, HEAR, and FEEL, at real speed. Frame 3 is the part everybody skips.

1 SET
See the mat, feel your stance, hear the whistle.

2 GO
Your first attack or first move.

3 GRIT
What she does to stop it.

4 ANSWER
Your adjustment. Keep wrestling.

IF-THEN PLANS: DECIDE NOW SO YOU DON'T HAVE TO DECIDE UNDER PRESSURE

Neutral: If she... **...then I will**

Top or bottom: If she... **...then I will**

Mental: If I give up the first takedown... **...then I will**

Ask a coach or partner: what obstacle do opponents use on me most? Write it as Frame 3 for your next script:

UNIT 6 / TEST IT ON THE MAT

Relentless

MAT TEST

Your choice: pick ONE. A skill you only write about is a skill you don't have.

☐ **A. Rehearse, Run, Refine**

Eyes closed, rehearse your 4 frames at real speed (about 15-30 sec). Drill it live at safe speed, then fix one detail in your script.

Date tried: _____ Tally / result:

☐ **B. If-Then Drill**

On the coach's signal, your partner gives you your Frame-3 obstacle. Run your 'then' immediately. Five reps, then switch.

Date tried: _____ Tally / result:

HONEST REFLECTION

Specifics beat feelings. Name the period, the position, the words.

1. **When you imagine your match, which part do you usually skip? Why do you think you skip it?**

2. **Which if-then plan fired this week, or would have? What happened, and what would you rewrite?**

REWIND: NO PEEKING

UNIT 5: Name two clips from your highlight reel.

UNIT 3: When is the Quick Reset better than the 4-4-4-4?

Then check back. Got it? ☐ yes ☐ partly ☐ not yet

SKILL LADDER

- ☐ **I can explain it** to a teammate without notes
- ☐ **I used it in practice** date _____
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- ☐ **It went into my "What Works for Me"** (p. 27)

UNIT 7 / LEARN

Resilient

Flip the Switch

Everyday mode off. Competition mode on.

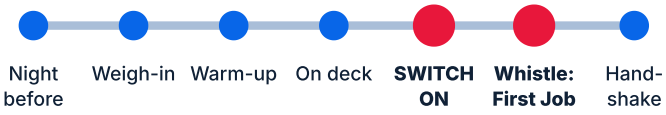
Skill you'll own: Build a Competition Process, a First Job, and a reset loop

MATCH MOMENT

Tournament day. Weigh-ins at 7:00, first match at 11:40, then two hours of waiting before your semi. Fifteen seconds into the semi, you give up the first takedown.

Before you read on: what would YOU do in the next 5 seconds?

MATCH-DAY PROCESS



AFTER ANY SCORE AGAINST YOU: THE RESET LOOP



FROM THE BOOK

Knight teaches a Competition Process to switch from everyday mode into competition mode, which his article calls the BIG-DOG switch. His publisher says mentally tough athletes instantly reset after mistakes, then battle for every inch. [K6 K3 K8]

Find it in your copy: Chapter ____ Page ____

One line from the book that stuck with me (write it, then say it in your own words):

THE SCIENCE

In a meta-analysis, athletes who used a pre-performance routine performed better, and the effect held under pressure (g = 0.70). Simple routines worked as well as complex ones (Rupprecht et al., 2021). Process goals beat outcome goals for performance by a wide margin (d = 1.36 vs. 0.09; Williamson et al., 2022). [S14 S9]

MERRILL

Resilient means returning to useful action after a mistake or lost point. Your First Job is the first controllable action at the whistle or restart. And after every match: KEEP WRESTLING - EVERYDAY IS A NEW MATCH!

UNIT 7 / BUILD YOUR TOOL

Resilient

My Competition Process

YOU UNIVERSITY ORIGINAL

Fill each stop with what YOU will do. Keep it short: a routine you can't run when you're rushed is no routine.

Night before

Weigh-in / arrival

Warm-up

On deck

Walk to center (SWITCH ON)

Between periods

Handshake (SWITCH OFF)

Long wait between matches

MY SWITCH-ON SIGNAL (ONE PHYSICAL ACTION)

MY RESET LOOP, IN MY WORDS

NOTICE → BREATHE → CUE → FIRST JOB

MY FIRST JOB (CONTROLLABLE, NOT AN OUTCOME)

Neutral

Top

Bottom

Ask a coach: which stop do I actually skip on tournament days? Write what they said:

UNIT 7 / TEST IT ON THE MAT

Resilient

MAT TEST

Your choice: pick ONE. A skill you only write about is a skill you don't have.

☐ **A. Full Dress Rehearsal**

Run your whole process before a practice match with a ref, a clock, and a score. Check off every stop you actually used.

Date tried: _____ Tally / result:

☐ **B. Bad Start Drill**

Start live goes down 0-2. Run your reset loop (Breathe, Cue, First Job) on the whistle. Your partner times how fast you're wrestling your plan.

Date tried: _____ Tally / result:

HONEST REFLECTION

Specifics beat feelings. Name the period, the position, the words.

1 **The last time you gave up the first point: how many seconds until you were wrestling your plan again? What pulled you back, or didn't?**

2 **Which step will you skip when you're rushed or nervous? How will you protect it?**

REWIND: NO PEEKING

UNIT 6: Write one if-then plan from memory.

UNIT 4: What's your go-to cue?

Then check back. Got it? ☐ yes ☐ partly ☐ not yet

SKILL LADDER

☐ **I can explain it** to a teammate without notes

☐ **I used it in practice** date _____

☐ **I used it in a match** date _____

☐ **It went into my "What Works for Me"** (p. 27)

CAPSTONE / BE YOU

Be You

What Works for Me

Your own manual, written by the only expert on you. Keep only what you've tested. Cross out what didn't work.

★ MERRILL

Be You. You don't win by copying someone else's mental game. Every tool in this book was built in your words, at your ready number, from your real matches.

My ready-zone number + up/down-shift moves

My breath: Long Breath before ___ / Quick Reset when ___

My BIG DOG cue (INSTRUCT + BELIEVE)

Top 3 highlight-reel clips

My best if-then plans

Switch-ON signal + First Jobs (neutral / top / bottom)

After a match, win or lose, I will...

When I wrestle like ME, people see...

CAPSTONE / CUT OUT + CARRY

Competition Card

Fill in only what you've tested. Cut along the dashed lines. Make a spare for your bag.

COMPETITION CARD no new teaching at mat-side

SWITCH ON

FIRST JOB

MY CUE

IF

THEN

RESET Notice → Breathe → Cue → First Job

COMPETITION CARD no new teaching at mat-side

SWITCH ON

FIRST JOB

MY CUE

IF

THEN

RESET Notice → Breathe → Cue → First Job

RESPECTFUL: LEAVE A DEPOSIT FOR A TEAMMATE

Be specific: what she did, when, and which Pillar it showed. Cut and hand it to her. Specific praise is proof she can use. "Good job" isn't.

CONFIDENCE BANK DEPOSIT

for: _____

I saw you...

That's _____ (Pillar)

CONFIDENCE BANK DEPOSIT

for: _____

I saw you...

That's _____ (Pillar)

CONFIDENCE BANK DEPOSIT

for: _____

I saw you...

That's _____ (Pillar)

TOOLS / copy this page

Practice Log

Coach Arnie's daily prompts. Thirty seconds before and after practice. Examples: *Single-leg finish · Be first to ties · Breathe and reset fast · Hit my escape first try · Move my feet on shots · Teammates*

PRACTICE 1

date _____

Practice Focus

Pillar Focus Persistent · Consistent · Resilient · Relentless

How will I show up today?

Went Well

Improve

Gratitude Trio

One C, 1-10 C: _____ pre ___ post ___

PRACTICE 2

date _____

Practice Focus

Pillar Focus Persistent · Consistent · Resilient · Relentless

How will I show up today?

Went Well

Improve

Gratitude Trio

One C, 1-10 C: _____ pre ___ post ___

PRACTICE 3

date _____

Practice Focus

Pillar Focus Persistent · Consistent · Resilient · Relentless

How will I show up today?

Went Well

Improve

Gratitude Trio

One C, 1-10 C: _____ pre ___ post ___

PRACTICE 4

date _____

Practice Focus

Pillar Focus Persistent · Consistent · Resilient · Relentless

How will I show up today?

Went Well

Improve

Gratitude Trio

One C, 1-10 C: _____ pre ___ post ___

TOOLS / copy this page, one per match

Film Room

The 24-hour rule: feel it, learn from it, then let it go. KEEP WRESTLING - EVERYDAY IS A NEW MATCH!

Date / event | **Opponent** | **Result / score**

MY PROCESS: CHECK WHAT I ACTUALLY DID

☐ Night before ☐ Weigh-in ☐ Warm-up ☐ On deck ☐ Switch ON ☐ First Job ☐ Between periods ☐ Switch OFF

Little-dog moment (exact words, when):

BIG DOG moment (what I said + what my body did):

What I did next (seconds until I was wrestling my plan):

If-then that fired, or one I need:

CONFIDENCE BANK DEPOSIT

IMPROVE: ONE PROCESS BEHAVIOR FOR NEXT PRACTICE

If I watched this match as my own coach, the one thing I'd tell myself:

RETEST

Finish Line: Five Cs

Same scale, same honesty. Growth is information, not a grade.

★ MERRILL

Merrill's **Five Cs** (from Coach Arnie's packet). Circle 1-10 for how often this shows up in REAL MATCHES, then write one piece of evidence. The total isn't the point. The pattern is.

C	1 = RARELY	10 = EVERY MATCH	EVIDENCE (A REAL MOMENT)
Commitment *Dedication to the work and the goal*	1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10		
Courage *Willingness to attempt, engage, and face challenge*	1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10		
Concentration *Keep or return attention to the job*	1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10		
Control *Regulate your response and stay useful*	1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10		
Confidence *Belief supported by preparation, mastery, and evidence*	1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10		

Compare to your Starting Line (p. 03). Which C moved most? What evidence explains the change? (Moving down can mean you got more honest. That counts.)

FINISH LINE / NEXT START

The Gap, Revisited

Go back to your Gap Map (Unit 1). Re-rate the same skills from memory first, then compare.

SKILL	MATCH-ME THEN	MATCH-ME NOW	EVIDENCE (A REAL MATCH MOMENT)

RETELL WITHOUT LOOKING: THE 3 TOOLS I'D KEEP IF I COULD ONLY KEEP 3

The tool I expected to help but didn't. Why do I think so?

My next Today's 1% for the next 7 days, and how I'll know it worked:

★ MERRILL

KEEP WRESTLING - EVERYDAY IS A NEW MATCH! The workbook ends here. The training doesn't. Recopy the Practice Log and Film Room pages and keep stacking 1% days.

FOR COACHES

Running YOU University

Short teaching, real reps, athlete choice. About 10 minutes a week of room time.

WEEKLY RHYTHM

MON · 5 min	Read the Match Moment aloud. Ask "what would you do?" before teaching. Athletes do the Learn page.
TUE-WED	Build page at home or in study hall. Fold Mat Test A or B into an existing live drill; don't add a new block.
THU · 2 min	Rewind out loud, no notes. Retrieval is the learning event, not a quiz grade [S15].
MEET	Competition Card only. No new teaching at mat-side.
NEXT MON	Film Room, then pick the next unit.

SUGGESTED SEASON MAP

Week 0	Start Here + Starting Line + Unit 1
Weeks 1-2	Unit 2 Love Nerves + Unit 3 Breath (pair them; breath is the body side of nerves)
Week 3	Unit 4 BIG DOG Talk
Week 4	Halftime Check + Unit 5 Bank the Proof
Week 5	Unit 6 Go-Time
Week 6	Unit 7 Flip the Switch, before your first big tournament
Week 7+	Capstone + Competition Card; Practice Log + Film Room all season
Postseason	Finish Line retest (Five Cs + Gap)

AUTONOMY-SUPPORTIVE COACHING [S16]

Offer choices (A or B), explain the why, acknowledge that it's hard, and recognize specific effort. Buy-in comes from choice, competence, and belonging, not from pressure.

MERRILL RECOGNITION TEMPLATE

Observation → program word → why it matters → next reinforcement.

"You gave up the first score, reset immediately, and attacked the next exchange. That is Resilient. Keep using the same reset."

GUARDRAILS

- This is performance training, not therapy. Self-ratings are not diagnoses.
- Never require personal disclosure. Allow written, verbal, or private answers.
- Mental toughness never means hiding pain, injury, or concussion symptoms.
- Follow WIAA/NFHS weight-management rules. Never praise unsafe cutting.
- If an athlete shares something that worries you, follow school referral procedures (counselor, AD, parent).
- Breathing drills: stop if dizzy, and never compete in breath-holding.
- Little Dog Drill (Unit 4): wrestling-only lines. Nothing personal, ever.

FOR COACHES / book alignment

What's Verified, What Isn't

This workbook doesn't pretend to know what's on pages we haven't read.

VERIFIED from the publisher	4th ed. (Edition 4.0), 164 pp., 7 chapters, Let's Win! International, ISBN 979-8-9882909-4-0 [K1]. The book focuses on competing, so athletes perform in competition as well as or better than in practice [K2].
VERIFIED Knight concepts	Love Nerves (Tactic #1) and the BIG-DOG switch [K3]; adrenaline as fuel and systematic breathing [K4]; confidence vs. mental toughness [K5]; Gut Breathing, BIG-DOG self-talk, Go-Time Visualization, BIG-DOG highlight reel, Competition Process [K6]; little dog / BIG Dog [K7]; instant reset [K8].
NOT verified	The book's chapter titles, chapter order, and which chapter covers which concept. Some concepts come from Knight's masterclass and articles, which use the book's language, so they may be organized differently in the book itself.
Independently developed	Every YOU-labeled exercise, Mat Test, reflection, and Rewind question in this workbook, plus the unit order. None of it is from the book.

COACH CHAPTER MAP: FILL THIS IN ONCE FROM THE ACTUAL BOOK, THEN SHARE WITH ATHLETES

CH.	CHAPTER TITLE (FROM THE BOOK)	BEST-MATCHING UNIT(S) + PAGES TO ASSIGN
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		
6		
7		

MERRILL LANGUAGE USED (MERRILL WRESTLING TERMS COMPENDIUM V1.0)

Verified: Persistent, Consistent, Resilient, Relentless; Respectful; the Five Cs; Coach Arnie's 4-4-4-4 breath; Practice Focus, Pillar Focus, "How will I show up today?", Went Well, Improve, Gratitude Trio; "KEEP WRESTLING - EVERYDAY IS A NEW MATCH!"; YOU University. Project terms: Today's 1%, First Job, Cue, If-Then Plan, Competition Card, Confidence Bank, What Works for Me. "Be You" per coach. Deliberately NOT used: an expansion of "BVOU," and legacy technique terms awaiting coach verification.

SOURCES

Where every claim comes from

BOOK + PUBLISHER (KNIGHT, WINNING STATE). PARAPHRASED. ACCESSED NOVEMBER 2026.

- **[K1]** WINNING STATE Wrestling product page, winningstate.com: 4th ed. (Edition 4.0), 164 pp., 7 chapters, Let's Win! International, ISBN 979-8-9882909-4-0. Chapter titles are not published there.
- **[K2]** Publisher description (e.g., Doylestown Bookshop / Amazon listing): the book focuses on competing, helping athletes eliminate distractions and 'crush apprehension' so they execute in competition as well as or better than in practice.
- **[K3]** Knight, S. 'Mental Toughness for Young Athletes: Tactics to Win Under Pressure (Part 1/7).' winningstate.com/post. Tactic #1: Love Nerves; the 'BIG-DOG switch.'
- **[K4]** Knight, S. 'Adrenaline: Think Differently.' winningstate.com/post. Adrenaline as a power source to contain and use; systematic breathing; focus on a positive process.
- **[K5]** Knight, S. 'Are Confidence and Mental Toughness the Same?' winningstate.com/post. Confidence is a fleeting feeling; doubt persists; mental toughness tactics win the battle.
- **[K6]** WINNING STATE Masterclass page, winningstate.com/masterclass-mental-toughness (Knight's course, which uses the book's language): competitor first; harness adrenaline; Gut Breathing and BIG-DOG self-talk; Go-Time Visualization; BIG-DOG highlight reel; Competition Process.
- **[K7]** Winning State series back-cover text (Winning State Baseball, 2004): 'a little dog and a BIG Dog' inside every competitor.
- **[K8]** winningstate.com home page: mentally tough athletes 'instantly reset' after mistakes, then battle for every inch.

RESEARCH

- **[S1]** Hatzigeorgiadis, A., et al. (2011). Self-talk and sports performance: A meta-analysis. Perspectives on Psychological Science, 6(4), 348-356. doi:10.1177/1745691611413136
- **[S2]** Chua, L.-K., Jimenez-Diaz, J., Lewthwaite, R., Kim, T., & Wulf, G. (2021). Superiority of external attentional focus for motor performance and learning: Systematic reviews and meta-analyses. Psychological Bulletin, 147(6), 618-645. doi:10.1037/bul0000335
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- **[S4]** Brooks, A. W. (2014). Get excited: Reappraising pre-performance anxiety as excitement. Journal of Experimental Psychology: General, 143(3), 1144-1158. doi:10.1037/a0035325
- **[S5]** Jamieson, J. P., Mendes, W. B., Blackstock, E., & Schmader, T. (2010). Turning the knots in your stomach into bows: Reappraising arousal improves performance on the GRE. Journal of Experimental Social Psychology, 46(1), 208-212.
- **[S6]** Hanin, Y. L. (2000). Emotions in Sport (Individual Zones of Optimal Functioning model). Human Kinetics.
- **[S7]** Balban, M. Y., et al. (2023). Brief structured respiration practices enhance mood and reduce physiological arousal. Cell Reports Medicine, 4(1), 100895. doi:10.1016/j.xcrm.2022.100895
- **[S8]** Bandura, A. (1997). Self-efficacy: The exercise of control. W. H. Freeman (mastery experiences as the strongest source of efficacy).
- **[S9]** Williamson, O., et al. (2022). The performance and psychological effects of goal setting in sport: A systematic review and meta-analysis. International Review of Sport and Exercise Psychology, 17(2), 1050-1078. doi:10.1080/1750984X.2022.2116723
- **[S10]** Duckworth, A. L., Grant, H., Loew, B., Oettingen, G., & Gollwitzer, P. M. (2011). Self-regulation strategies improve self-discipline in adolescents: Benefits of mental contrasting and implementation intentions. Educational Psychology, 31(1), 17-26. doi:10.1080/01443410.2010.506003
- **[S11]** Gollwitzer, P. M., & Sheeran, P. (2006). Implementation intentions and goal achievement: A meta-analysis of effects and processes. Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 38, 69-119.
- **[S12]** Frank, C., Kluever, J., & Simonsmeier, B. A. (2023). Imagery training in children and adolescents: A meta-analysis. International Review of Sport and Exercise Psychology. doi:10.1080/1750984X.2023.2167225
- **[S13]** Holmes, P. S., & Collins, D. J. (2001). The PETTLEP approach to motor imagery. Journal of Applied Sport Psychology, 13(1), 60-83.
- **[S14]** Rupprecht, A. G. O., Tran, U. S., & Gröpel, P. (2021). The effectiveness of pre-performance routines in sports: A meta-analysis. International Review of Sport and Exercise Psychology, 17(1), 39-64. doi:10.1080/1750984X.2021.1944271
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- **[S16]** Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000). Self-determination theory and the facilitation of intrinsic motivation. American Psychologist, 55(1), 68-78; Mageau, G. A., & Vallerand, R. J. (2003). The coach-athlete relationship: A motivational model. Journal of Sports Sciences, 21(11), 883-904.
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Effect sizes (d, g) describe average effects in studies. They don't promise results for any one wrestler. That's why every tool here gets tested on the mat and kept only if it works for you.